

THE PM INTERVIEW ANSWER GUIDE · PRODUCT SENSE, ESTIMATION, THE CLOSE

# He Got the Offer. Here's the Difference.

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Same questions. Same 45 minutes. One candidate answers the question he heard. The other answers the question the interviewer is actually asking. These are the three answers that decide it — what the weak version sounds like, why it ends the interview, and what to say instead.

## 1 Ask who it's for before you say what it does

Product sense questions sound like design questions. They aren't. When they ask you to improve a product or build one from scratch, the interviewer is testing whether you think like an owner: who is this for, what problem are they living with, and how would you know you fixed it?

The answer that ends it: *"I'd just add the features users keep asking for."* That tells them you'd build whatever is loudest, for whoever shouts. Features are the last thing a strong candidate talks about, not the first.

### EXAMPLE

*"First — who's this for, and what does success look like? Then I'll prioritize."*

## 2 Prioritize out loud, with the trade-off

Once you've named the user and the goal, rank your ideas in the open and say what you're giving up. Interviewers can't score reasoning they can't hear. "I'd build all three" is not a strategy — it's a refusal to choose, and choosing is the job.

Name your measure before your winner: if success is activation, the onboarding fix beats the new feature, and you should be able to say why in one breath.

### EXAMPLE

*"I'd start with the onboarding fix over the new feature. Activation is our number, most users drop before they ever reach the feature — and here's how I'd check in the first 30 days."*

### 3 Break it apart before you touch a number

Estimation questions are not math tests. Nobody cares whether the true answer is 6 million or 8 million.

They care whether you can take a question with no edges and give it structure before you give it a number.

The answer that ends it: *"Uh... probably a few million? I'm not really sure."* A guess with no layers gives the interviewer nothing to follow — and nothing to hire. Write the layers down first, then work them top down, out loud, with a reason for every number. Like this:

#### ***How many cups of coffee are sold in New York City today?***

People in NYC: about 8 million

- Share who drink coffee on a given day: say half  $\rightarrow 8M \times 50\% = 4M$  drinkers
- Cups per drinker: about 1.5  $\rightarrow 4M \times 1.5 = 6M$  cups
- Add commuters and visitors who buy in the city: + about 1M

**$\approx 7$  million cups today**

### 4 Check your number before you sit down

A strong estimation answer doesn't end at the number. It ends with the check. Say the figure, say which assumption you're least sure of, and say how you'd verify it if this were your job. That last move is the one that sounds like a PM instead of a student.

If they push back, don't start over. Change the one assumption you're least sure of, out loud, and rerun the math from that layer down.

#### **EXAMPLE**

*"Let me break it apart — market, segments, frequency. Here's my number, and here's how I'd check it."*

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## End the interview like someone who wants the job

"Do you have any questions for us?" is not a formality. It's the last scored answer of the interview, and most candidates spend it on perks or throw it away completely.

The answer that ends it: *"No, I don't have any questions."* You just told them you're not curious about the role you're asking them to give you. Ask the question that makes them picture you in the seat — then follow it with the one that shows you want to win in it, not just land it.

### EXAMPLE

*"What does success in this role look like in the first 90 days?"*

*"And what separates the PMs who succeed here from the ones who don't?"*

## Score every answer

Use this checklist after each practice run:

- ☐ Did I ask who it's for before naming a feature?
- ☐ Did I say what success looks like before I prioritized?
- ☐ Did I break the estimate into layers before any math?
- ☐ Did I give a reason for every number I used?
- ☐ Did I state my final number and how I'd check it?
- ☐ Did I end with a real question about the role?
- ☐ Did I sound like I already work there?